

Your Third Space: *Creating a Clear Pathway to Independence for Youth*

Team Number: C5 – Transitions to Independence

Team Members:

Ghada Ahmed (*Faculty of Engineering*)

Wynter Farrell (*Faculty of Environmental & Urban Change*)

Insha Waseem (*Lassonde School Of Engineering*)

Mustafa Faqiry (*Faculty of Liberal Arts and Professional Studies*)

York University & University of Ottawa

C4 3.0 – Cross Campus Capstone Classroom

Community Partner(s): Youth Services Bureau, Better Street, Trek for Teens, Reena,
HICC, 360 Kids

June 14, 2026

Table of Contents

Project Statement	3
Project Justification	4
Project Design Thinking.....	5
The Project Itself.....	7
Ethics Statement	9
Connection to the SDG Goals	10
Process of Completion	11
Project Management Reflection.....	13
Interdisciplinary Reflection.....	14
AI Declaration	16
References	17
Bibliography	19
Appendix A.....	20
Appendix B	21
Appendix C	22
Appendix D.....	23
Appendix E	24

Project Statement

Your Third Space is a project designed to support youth between the ages of 16 and 26 who are transitioning out of homelessness and working toward independent living. Through our research, we found that many young people face significant challenges related to housing, employment, budgeting, and accessing support services during this transition. Without adequate guidance and preparation, these challenges can lead to financial instability, housing insecurity, and difficulty maintaining long-term independence.

The goal of this project is to help youth develop the skills, confidence, and support networks needed to successfully navigate adulthood. Rather than focusing on homelessness, our project concentrates on the critical transition period when youth leave shelters, support programs, or unstable living situations and begin building independent lives. By narrowing our focus, we were able to identify realistic opportunities to provide meaningful support during this stage.

Our final solution is a digital platform called *Your Third Space*. The platform combines mentorship, an Adulting Simulation, an AI Coach, and access to community resources in one accessible location. The mentorship component connects youth with individuals who have lived experience and can provide guidance and encouragement throughout the transition process. The Adulting Simulation allows users to practice real-world situations such as budgeting, housing decisions, employment challenges, grocery shopping, and unexpected emergencies in a safe environment. The AI Coach provides immediate support and answers questions when a mentor may not be available, while the resource hub connects users with relevant community services and supports.

The project aligns with several United Nations Sustainable Development Goals, including No Poverty (SDG 1), Quality Education (SDG 4), Decent Work and Economic Growth (SDG 8), Sustainable Cities and Communities (SDG 11), and Partnerships for the Goals (SDG 17). By helping youth build practical life skills and connect with supportive networks, the project aims to improve transition outcomes and reduce the risk of future housing instability.

The primary stakeholders for this project include youth transitioning to independence, shelters and homelessness support organizations, community centres, youth hubs, mentors with lived experience, and social service providers. While the project does not directly provide housing, employment, or financial assistance, it seeks to prepare youth for independent living by offering practical learning opportunities, guidance, and access to resources. Ultimately, the purpose of *Your Third Space* is to empower young people with the knowledge, confidence, and support they need to successfully navigate adulthood and create stable futures.

Project Justification

Our project was informed by a combination of academic research, government reports, community-based studies, and feedback from community partners. A key finding throughout the research was that youth transitioning out of homelessness often struggle not only because of financial hardship, but also because they lack guidance, preparation, and access to support systems. The Government of Canada's *Homelessness Data Snapshot* (2024) and research by Starr et al. (2024) highlighted how inadequate support during transitional periods can contribute to long-term housing instability and chronic homelessness. This evidence helped us define our problem more narrowly, focusing on the transition to independence rather than attempting to solve homelessness as a whole.

Research from REST Centres emphasized that financial literacy is a fundamental right and that many youth experiencing homelessness have not been given the opportunity to develop practical money-management skills. Similarly, Koyi (2022) demonstrated how targeted financial literacy programs can help youth overcome barriers to independence. These findings directly influenced our decision to include interactive financial literacy challenges and real-world simulation games within our digital platform. Rather than simply providing information, we wanted youth to actively practice budgeting, managing credit, finding housing, and making financial decisions in a low-risk environment.

Our decision to incorporate mentorship was strongly supported by research showing that supportive adult relationships improve long-term outcomes for vulnerable youth. Blum (2021) and Armstrong (2025) found that mentorship, particularly from individuals with relevant lived experiences, can increase confidence, engagement, and overall stability. This led us to design a mentorship model where every participant is matched with a dedicated mentor while also having access to specialized mentors who understand LGBTQ+ experiences, Indigenous perspectives, and other unique challenges. Research by Poon et al. (2022) also informed our implementation plan by highlighting the importance of mentor training, supervision, and careful matching to ensure positive mentor-mentee relationships.

Reflection on Testing and Validation

As our project evolved, we continually tested and validated our assumptions through research, feedback from community partners, classroom discussions, and the Five Whys analysis process. Initially, our team proposed a mentorship program and a personalized survival guidebook as separate solutions. However, feedback suggested that youth needed a more engaging, accessible, and comprehensive approach. Through continued research and reflection, we recognized that both solutions could be integrated into a larger ecosystem that combined practical learning, mentorship, and community support.

This validation process ultimately led to the development of *Your Third Space*, a hybrid online and in-person community designed to meet youth where they are. The final project reflects what we learned throughout the design process: youth need more than information alone—they need opportunities to practice life skills, build relationships, access resources, and develop confidence in a supportive environment. By grounding our decisions in evidence and continuously refining our ideas based on feedback, we created a solution that better addresses the root causes identified in our research and offers a more holistic pathway to independence.

Project Design Thinking

SOUnd Thinking Process

Our team utilized the SOUnd framework to ensure that our solution was socially responsible, user-centered, and sustainable. We began by identifying a specific challenge within youth homelessness: the difficult transition from housing insecurity to independent living. Through stakeholder research, community partner feedback (see Appendix B), and our Five Whys analysis (see Appendix A), we narrowed our focus to lack of accessible life-skills education, mentorship, and support systems available to youth during this transition period. By continuously refining our ideas and seeking feedback, we developed a solution that addresses both immediate and long-term needs.

Sustainability

The sustainability of Your Third Space is rooted in its hybrid structure. The digital platform can be scaled to support a large number of users at relatively low cost, while the mentorship model leverages community involvement and partnerships with local organizations. The project also promotes long-term sustainability by equipping youth with practical skills that can improve housing stability, employment outcomes, and financial independence.

Out-of-the-Box Thinking

Rather than creating another informational resource or mentorship program, our team combined multiple supports into a single ecosystem. The integration of an adulting simulation, mentorship network, and physical third-space environment creates an engaging and interactive experience that allows youth to learn through practice rather than passive instruction.

Universal Design

Accessibility was a major consideration throughout the design process. The platform is designed to be accessible to youth with varying educational backgrounds, experiences, and support needs. Information is presented through multiple formats,

including simulations, mentorship conversations and guidance, and resource directories. Specialized mentors and inclusive resources also support diverse populations, including indigenous youth, LGBTQ+ youth, and other marginalized groups.

Evaluation Criteria

The success of the project was evaluated using several criteria:

- Accessibility for youth transitioning to independence
- Practical application of life-skills learning
- Scalability and sustainability
- User engagement
- Inclusivity and equity
- Alignment with stakeholder needs and community partner feedback

Ideation Process

Our ideation process began with extensive brainstorming sessions and a Five Why's analysis, we explored several broad themes related to homelessness before narrowing our focus to transition-to-independence challenges. Team members proposed numerous solutions including mentorship programs, survival guidebooks, workshops, mobile applications, and community spaces.

Alternative Solutions

The main alternative solution considered during the project was the development of a financial literacy and life-skills guidebook. This option would have provided young people with accessible information and practical guidance on topics such as budgeting, employment, housing, and independent living. While the guidebook could serve as a useful resource, it lacked the personalized support, mentorship, and sense of community that our final solution aimed to provide. As a result, we determined that a more comprehensive approach would better address the challenges faced by youth transitioning to independence.

Convergence Process

Through our research, partner feedback, and team discussions, we recognized that the strongest solution would combine the strengths of multiple ideas. This convergence process led to the development of Your Third Space, which integrates mentorship, experiential learning, and community resources into one cohesive platform.

Testing and Validation

Throughout the project, our ideas were tested through classroom discussions, partner feedback, literature reviews, and iterative prototyping. User testing of the website

and simulation helped identify areas for improvement, while community partner insights validated the need for mentorship and life-skills support.

Final Solution

The final solution is *Your Third Space*, a hybrid digital and community-based platform designed to bridge the gap between housing insecurity and independent living. By combining mentorship, experiential learning, and access to resources, the platforms help youth develop the skills, confidence, and support networks necessary for a successful transition to independence.

The Project Itself

Project Overview

Your Third Space is a hybrid support platform designed to help youth between the ages of 16 and 26 successfully transition from housing insecurity to independent living. Rather than focusing solely on homelessness, the project addresses the critical gap between obtaining housing and maintaining long-term independence. The platform combines life-skills education, mentorship, experiential learning, and community support to help youth develop the confidence and practical skills necessary to navigate adulthood.

The project is built around the belief that independence is not achieved simply by securing housing. True independence requires financial literacy, employment readiness, housing knowledge, decision-making skills, and access to supportive relationships. *Your Third Space* was designed to bridge this gap by creating an accessible and engaging environment where youth can learn, practice, and apply these skills before facing them alone in real-world situations.

Project Outputs and Assets

The project consists of several interconnected components:

- *Your Third Space* website
- Adulting Simulation
- Mentorship program
- Resource Hub
- Community and Third-Space features
- Physical Third-Space Concept Model

Together, these components create a comprehensive support ecosystem rather than a single standalone service.

Website / Platform

The website serves as the central hub of the project. It provides youth with access to educational resources, mentorship opportunities, simulation activities, and community supports through a single platform.

The website was designed to be user-friendly and accessible, allowing participants to navigate between resources, communicate with mentors, and engage with learning activities. By centralizing these supports, the platform reduces barriers that often prevent youth from finding and utilizing available resources.

Mentorship Program

The mentorship platform is one of the core pillars of *Your Third Space*. Participants are paired with mentors who provide guidance, encouragement, accountability, and support throughout their transition to independence. The mentor is the key component towards implementation of what is learnt through the online portion to ensure a balance between learning and implementing what is learnt.

Mentors may include individuals with lived experience, trained volunteers, community professionals, or post-secondary students interested in supporting youth development. The mentorship relationship is intended to help participants navigate challenges related to employment, housing, financial management, education, and personal growth.

In addition to general mentorship, the program aims to provide specialized mentors who can support youth from diverse backgrounds, including indigenous youth, LGBTQ+ youth, newcomers, and other marginalized populations.

Adulting Simulation

The adulting simulation is an interactive learning experience that allows participants to practice real-world decision-making in a safe environment.

Through a series of scenarios, users are presented with challenges related to budgeting, employment, housing, grocery shopping, transportation, emergencies, and financial planning. Participants must make decisions and experience realistic consequences based on their choices.

The purpose of the simulation is to provide experiential learning opportunities that build confidence and practical problem-solving skills before youth encounter these situations in real life.

Resource Hub

The resource Hub connects participants to relevant community services and support organizations. Resources may include:

- Housing services
- Employment programs
- Financial literacy supports
- Mental health services
- Crisis supports
- Indigenous services
- LGBTQ+ supports
- Educational opportunities

The goal is to simplify access to information by consolidating resources into one easily navigable location.

Community Features

A key component of the project is the creation of community and belonging. Youth experiencing housing insecurity often face isolation and limited social support networks.

To address this challenge, *Your Third Space* incorporates community-building opportunities through mentorship, peer engagement, workshops, and the concept of a physical third-space environment. These features encourage participants to build relationships, share experiences, and develop support systems that extend beyond the platform itself.

Ethics Statement

Ethics played a central role in the development of *Your Third Space*. From the beginning of the project, our team was guided by the principles of empathy, respect, inclusion, equity, and responsibility. Rather than viewing youth experiencing housing insecurity as individuals who need to be “fixed”, we approached the problem from an empowerment perspective, recognizing that many youth lack access to the resources, opportunities, and support systems necessary to successfully transition to independence.

Our solution was heavily influenced by the Ethics of Care framework, which emphasizes the importance of relationships, trust, and human connection. This ethical perspective directly informed our decision to include a mentorship program within the platform. We recognized that providing information alone is often sufficient; youth can also benefit from meaningful relationships with trusted individuals who can offer guidance, encouragement, and support throughout their transition to independent living.

Equity and inclusion were also key ethical considerations. Youth experiencing housing insecurity come from diverse backgrounds and often face different barriers based on their identities, experiences, and circumstances. To address this, we designed the

project to be accessible to a wide range of users and envisioned mentorship opportunities and resources that reflect the diversity of the communities being served. This includes populations that may face additional challenges when transitioning to independence.

Ultimately, the ethical goal of *Your Third Space* is to promote dignity, independence, and equal opportunity. By prioritizing care, inclusion, empowerment, and responsible support, the project seeks to create a safe and respectful pathway that helps youth navigate the transition from housing insecurity to independent living.

Connection to the SDG Goals

Our SDG assessment (see Appendix C) identified several Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) that are positively supported by our project, *Your Third Space*. The strongest alignment is with No Poverty (SDG 1), Quality Education (SDG 4), Decent Work and Economic Growth (SDG 8), Sustainable Cities and Communities (SDG 11), and Partnerships for the Goals (SDG 17). The project addresses the root causes of financial instability among youth transitioning to independence by providing practical life-skills education, financial literacy training, and access to supportive mentorship. Through interactive simulation games, youth can safely practice budgeting, housing decisions, employment preparation, and other essential life skills. The mentorship component connects participants with trusted adults who can provide guidance, support, and encouragement, while partnerships with community organizations strengthen access to resources and services.

The project also indirectly supports Zero Hunger (SDG 2) and Good Health and Well-Being (SDG 3). By helping youth develop financial stability, access housing, and build support networks, the project can improve food security, reduce stress, and contribute to better physical and mental health outcomes.

Reflection on the Impact Assessment

Overall, our final project successfully achieved many of the impacts identified in the SDG assessment. Compared to our original ideas of a mentorship program and survival guidebook, *Your Third Space* provides a more comprehensive and engaging solution. The online platform offers accessible, interactive learning opportunities, while the physical community café creates a welcoming environment where youth can connect with mentors and peers. The project directly addresses the identified need for practical, youth-focused financial literacy and transition support. Additionally, the inclusion of specialized mentors for LGBTQ+ youth, Indigenous youth, and other marginalized groups helps create a more inclusive and equitable support system.

However, some challenges remain. The success of the project depends on maintaining mentor availability, ensuring youth remain engaged with the platform, and securing long-term funding for both the digital and physical spaces. While the project can significantly improve preparedness for independence, it cannot fully address broader systemic issues such as affordable housing shortages or poverty.

Increasing SDG Impact

To further increase our SDG impact, we could expand partnerships with schools, shelters, community organizations, and employers to provide additional opportunities for education, employment, and housing support (SDG's 4, 8, and 1). Adding workshops led by financial professionals, housing experts, and employers could strengthen participants' readiness for independent living. We could also introduce impact tracking measures, such as monitoring improvements in financial literacy, employment outcomes, housing stability, and participant well-being.

Process of Completion

Team Contributions

Our project team consisted of four undergraduate student members and two masters student managers who provided overarching guidance:

- Insha: Website Developer and Integration Specialist.
- Mustafa: Technical Developer and Game Creator.
- Wynter: Lead Researcher, Content Strategist, and Partner Communication.
- Ghada: Researcher and 3D Environmental Designer (Remote).
- Kumar & Kay: Project Managers, tracking timelines, managing scope, and facilitating partner communication.

Sprint 1 Summary

During the initial sprint, our team held a collaborative alignment session to solidify financial instability among youth aged 16 to 26 facing homelessness as our core focus, ultimately determining that a website would serve as our primary concrete solution. To optimize efficiency, we split into specialized sub-teams: Wynter and Ghada spear-headed the foundational research, gathering vital statistics, essential resources, and references to shape the website's content, while Mustafa and Insha held responsibility for technical development. Mustafa proposed integrating an interactive financial literacy game into the project, leading to a workflow where Insha focused on the website architecture and Mustafa took ownership of the game prototype, collaborating closely via a shared GitHub repository. Throughout this phase, our senior managers, Kay and

Kumar, actively monitored our progress to prevent scope creep, ensuring our collective ideas remained grounded, practical, and aligned with our deadlines.

Sprint 2 Summary

The second sprint focused on translating our foundational concepts into tangible prototypes as both development teams and research teams synchronized their initial outputs. Insha and Mustafa successfully delivered the first iterations of the website and the game; however, we hit an immediate technical roadblock when the game, originally built on the Bolt platform, encountered severe loading and compatibility issues across different web browsers. While Insha worked alongside Mustafa to debug these deployment errors, Wynter and Ghada successfully finalized their comprehensive research phase. The team then established a workflow to systematically organize this raw data into formal documentation, preparing it for Insha to code directly into the live website interface once the game's stability issues were resolved.

Sprint 3 Summary

In the third sprint, our team focused heavily on feature expansion, pivot strategies, and spatial design under the continuous guidance of our managers and teammates. After consulting with Ghada, Wynter, Mustafa and Kumar, Insha integrated critical content updates into the website, implementing a live chat function for youth and adding several resource tabs to enhance user navigation. Simultaneously, due to the persistent compatibility issues discovered in the previous sprint, Mustafa executed a technical pivot by successfully rebuilding the entire financial literacy game on a more compatible platform called Lovable. Following this breakthrough, Insha took on the complex task of embedding and connecting Mustafa's new game URL directly into the website infrastructure. Meanwhile, leveraging their research insights, Wynter, Ghada, and Kumar brainstormed a brilliant expansion for our pitch, leading Ghada to begin designing a detailed 3D model visualizing what this physical "third space" internet cafe would look like in the real world.

Sprint 4 Summary

The final sprint was dedicated to integration, rigorous quality assurance, and pitch preparation to ensure a seamless final delivery. Insha successfully completed the technical loop by embedding a dedicated launch button on the website that routed users directly to the external URL of Mustafa's newly stabilized game. With the integration live, the entire team conducted extensive user testing and proofreading sessions, running through the website and game mechanics multiple times to eliminate bugs and formatting errors. Concurrently, Ghada and Wynter collaborated on refining the architectural details of the 3D model while proactively drafting a list of potential questions our project partners might ask during the evaluation. Sprint 4 concluded with the entire team, alongside Kay and Kumar, running timed presentation dress rehearsals to perfect our positioning, timing, and narrative flow before the final pitch.

Project Management Reflection

What Worked Well

Our project's success was largely driven by a clear division of labor that mapped directly to each team member's unique strengths. The separation of technical development (Insha and Mustafa) from research and design (Wynter and Ghada) allowed us to work in parallel without bottlenecking each other. Additionally, the vertical structure provided by our senior student managers, Kay and Kumar, was incredibly effective. Having dedicated managers monitoring our progress prevented overthinking, kept our scope realistic, and ensured team accountability, such as Kay keeping everyone aligned on Miro and enforcing strict deadlines.

Challenges Faced

Our primary obstacles were technical integration and physical production constraints. On the development side, Mustafa faced a massive hurdle when the original game build on Bolt failed to render across multiple web browsers, forcing a time-sensitive, stressful platform migration to Lovable midway through the project lifecycle. Furthermore, linking the external game URL to the website framework without breaking the user interface proved to be complex. On the design side, Ghada faced significant setbacks regarding the physical layout, sizing, and precise shapes required to get the 3D model of the third-space internet cafe to render and print accurately.

Communication Reflection

Communication across our hybrid team was highly engaging, consistent, and structurally organized. Because Ghada participated remotely, we had to be incredibly intentional about digital transparency. We successfully utilized a centralized WhatsApp group, spearheaded by Kumar and Kay, where daily deliverables, individual task deadlines, and progress reminders were broadcasted to keep everyone in the loop. Kumar's leadership style was exceptionally patient and respectful; when friction or misunderstandings arose regarding project direction, he calmly mediated the discussions, validated everyone's perspectives, and translated conflicting opinions into clear, actionable steps. His practice of sending personal check-in messages ensured that workloads remained manageable and that no team member felt isolated or stuck.

Future Improvements

While our final deliverables—the website, the game, and the 3D model—provided concrete, high-quality touchpoints, our partner evaluations revealed that our underlying operational strategy still requires refinement. In future iterations of this program, we need to look beyond the software and map out the real-world execution. Specifically, we must define the exact logistics of the mentorship matchmaking process,

establish solid volunteer mentor incentives to prevent ghosting, and address safety, privacy, and vetting protocols. Moving forward, we will utilize our digital workspaces to map out a comprehensive "User Journey" and build an operational appendix that explicitly answers these backend structural questions alongside our visual prototypes.

Interdisciplinary Reflection

Our project's heart beat across four very different minds, blending the human-centric focus of Environmental Studies (Wynter), the architectural logic of Computer Science (Insha), the rapid user-experience delivery of Information Technology (Mustafa), and the physical precision of Biomedical Mechanical Engineering (Ghada). In the beginning, we were just four students looking at the massive, systemic crisis of youth homelessness through completely different lenses, trying to figure out how to build a bridge between abstract human suffering and rigid technical solutions. Wynter anchored us to the raw reality of the issue, bringing in the vital demographics and ethical data for youth aged 16 to 26, while Insha took that massive wave of qualitative research and structured it into clean website pathways. At the same time, Mustafa worked from an IT perspective to keep user interaction engaging, sparking the idea to turn dry budgeting statistics into an active learning tool through a financial literacy game, while Ghada stepped away from the digital screen entirely, applying her engineering mindset to calculate the exact structural dimensions, ergonomics, and spatial constraints needed to design our physical "third space" internet cafe model.

Achieving true synthesis between these worlds was easily our steepest learning curve, largely because we spent the early stages of the project speaking completely different academic languages. Our developers were focused on APIs, hosting, and platform constraints, our researcher was trying to protect the complex nuances of systemic poverty, and our engineer was isolated in a world of physical measurements, creating a massive translation barrier when we finally tried to merge our ideas. For instance, trying to flatten the messy, unpredictable realities of financial instability into rigid coding logic rules for the game required stripping away the very human elements that the environmental perspective valued, just as trying to display a tangible, physical 3D engineering model inside a flat digital software ecosystem felt incredibly disconnected.

We finally broke through these barriers and achieved genuine synthesis by forcing our tools to talk to one another, most notably in the creation of our interactive educational game and our digital-physical cafe. The game became a direct hybrid of our fields; Wynter provided the real-world financial traps and budgeting hurdles faced by unhoused youth, and Mustafa and Insha successfully synthesized those human stories into quantitative mechanics and coding algorithms, turning stats into an empathetic learning

simulation. We mirrored this success by linking our physical and digital designs, where Ghada engineered the physical blueprint of the cafe space, Insha coded the digital portal to host it, and Wynter tied the entire narrative together during our pitches, explaining exactly how the physical layout protected human safety and how the website supported that community.

Ultimately, this interdisciplinary synthesis didn't happen by accident; it was actively facilitated by the project management structure our senior managers, Kumar and Kay, forced us to maintain. By keeping us tied to shared visual workspaces like Miro and a central WhatsApp stream, they created a neutral zone where our different academic mindsets could align and translate ideas in real-time. This journey taught us our most valuable lesson: complex social problems cannot be solved in a silo, because while computer scientists can build beautiful platforms, they lack empathy without social research, and deep research remains trapped in theory without engineers and developers to build concrete, scalable solutions.

AI Declaration

Artificial intelligence tools were used as a brainstorming and drafting aid during the development of this report. All content was reviewed, edited, and verified by the project team before submission.

References

- Achola, E. O., & Greene, G. (2016). Person-family centered transition planning: Improving post-school outcomes to culturally diverse youth and families. *Journal of Vocational Rehabilitation*, 45(2), 173–183. <https://doi.org/10.3233/jvr-160821>
- Armstrong, D. (2025, February 17). *Lived Experience is Vital to Positively Impacting At-Risk Youth*. The Imprint. <https://imprintnews.org/youth-voice/lived-experience-is-vital-to-positively-impacting-at-risk-youth/258847>
- Blum, A. & Joan B. Kroc Institute for Peace and Justice. (2021). *Mentoring and lived experience mentoring*. <https://catcher.sandiego.edu/items/peacestudies/PSN-Evidence-Review-Mentoring-FNL.pdf>
- Cobb, R. B., & Alwell, M. (2009). Transition Planning/Coordinating Interventions for Youth with Disabilities. *Career Development for Exceptional Individuals*, 32(2), 70–81. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0885728809336655>
- Government of Canada. (2024). *Homelessness Data Snapshot: Youth Homelessness in Canada*. <https://housing-infrastructure.canada.ca/homelessness-sans-abri/reports-rapports/youth-homelessness-2024-itinerance-jeunes-eng.html>
- Homeless Hub. (2019). *Untangling the connection between youth homelessness and failed encounters with the healthcare system*. <https://homelesshub.ca/blog/2019/untangling-connection-youth-homelessness-and-failed-encounters-healthcare-system/>
- Homeless Hub. (2024). *Youth homelessness prevention mapping report*. https://homelesshub.ca/wp-content/uploads/2025/08/2024_12-Youth-Homelessness-Prevention-Mapping-ReportFINAL.pdf
- International Labour Organization (ILO). (2024). *Global employment trends for youth 2024*. <https://www.ilo.org/publications/major-publications/global-employment-trends-youth-2024>
- Kaya, Y. B., Maass, K. L., Dimas, G. L., Konrad, R., Trapp, A. C., & Dank, M. (2022). Improving access to housing and supportive services for runaway and homeless youth: Reducing vulnerability to human trafficking in New York City. *arXiv (Cornell University)*. <https://doi.org/10.48550/arxiv.2202.00138>
- Koyi, D. (2022, October 21). *Financial Literacy: Helping Youth overcome homelessness*. REST CENTRES. <https://www.restcentres.org/ourstories/financial-literacy-helping-youth-overcome-homelessness>
- Lkhagvasuren, D., & Tuvaandorj, P. (2025). Labor Market Impact on Homelessness: Evidence from Canadian Administrative Data on Shelter Usage. *ArXiv.org*. <https://doi.org/10.48550/arxiv.2503.23259>

- Poon, C. Y. S., Herrera, C., Jarjoura, R., McQuillin, S. D., Keller, T. E., & Rhodes, J. E. (2022). Deconstructing “Risk” in Youth Mentoring Programs: How environmental stressors and presenting challenges shape mentoring relationship outcomes. *The Journal of Early Adolescence*, 42(6), 793–821.
<https://doi.org/10.1177/02724316221078833>
- Sherman, E. (2024). *Study reveals Gen Z relies heavily on credit cards to handle financial emergencies*. Parents. <https://www.parents.com/study-reveals-gen-z-relies-heavily-on-credit-cards-to-handle-financial-emergencies-11798178>
- Starr, et al. (2024). *Longitudinal systematic review*. *PLOS ONE*.
<https://journals.plos.org/plosone/article?id=10.1371/journal.pone.0304965>
- Youngren, M., & Dworsky, A. (2025). Transition Planning For Youth In Systems Of Care: A Literature-informed Framework. In *Chapin Hall* [Report]. Chapin Hall.
<https://www.dhs.state.il.us/OneNetLibrary/27897/documents/Homelessness/Chapin%20Hall%20080525%20accessible%20YHPS%20LITERATURE%20REVIEW%20discharge%20planningA11Y%20%28002%29.pdf>

Bibliography

- Beal, J. (2024, September 24). *What are Third Places and Why Do They Matter?* Albert Shanker Institute. <https://www.shankerinstitute.org/blog/what-are-third-places-and-why-do-they-matter>
- CPRA *Youth Employment Experience Mentorship Guide*. (2021). Canadian Parks and Recreation Association. https://mentorcanada.ca/sites/default/files/2021-10/Youth%20Employment%20Experience%20-%20Mentorship%20Guide_EN.pdf
- Funding Opportunities*. (n.d.). Toronto Foundation. <https://torontofoundation.ca/funding-opportunities>
- Koyi, D. (2024, July 5). *Youth Homelessness in Canada: Housing as a fundamental right for all — REST CENTRES*. REST CENTRES. <https://www.restcentres.org/ourstories/fundamentalright>
- Our Grants*. (n.d.). Ontario Trillium Foundation. <https://otf.ca/our-grants>
- Porter-Burns, A., & Parks, F. (2014). *The Keys To Creating Successful Mentor-Mentee Matches* [Slide show]. Demystifying Matching National Mentoring Summit. Big Brothers Big Sisters of North Bay. <https://mentoring.org/wp-content/uploads/2019/11/Demystifying-Matching.pdf>
- Quality mentoring system*. (n.d.). Mentor Canada. <https://qualitymentoring.ca/en>
- Starting a Youth Mentoring Program*. (n.d.). MENTOR. <https://mentoring.org/resource/introduction-setting-the-stage/>
- What's your third place?* (2025). School Mental Health Ontario. <https://smho-smso.ca/whats-your-third-place/>
- Youth Homelessness*. (n.d.). Covenant House Toronto. <https://covenanthousetoronto.ca/our-solution/education-and-employment/>

Appendix A

Five Why's Analysis

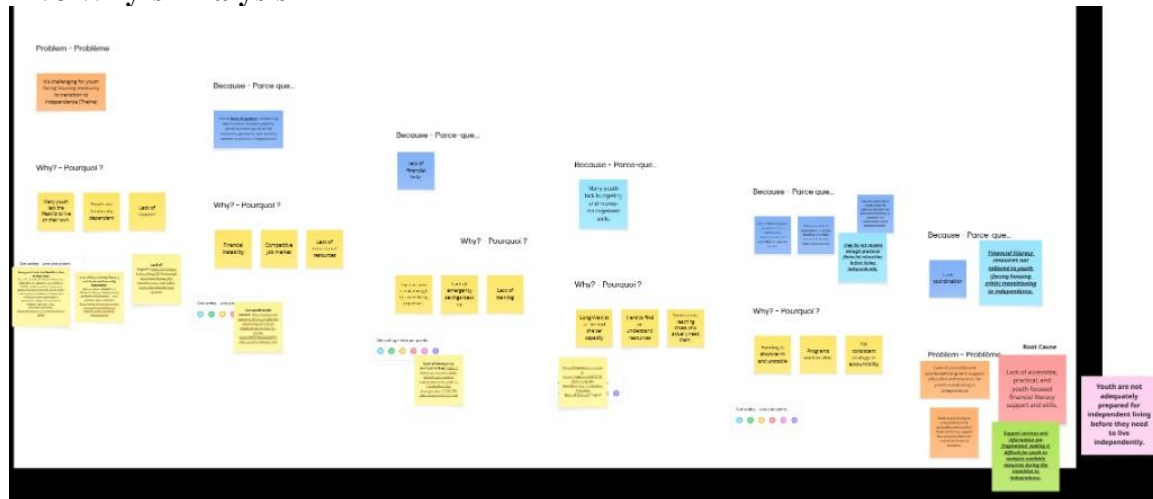


Figure 1: An image of the 5 why's brainstorming process

This appendix documents the raw, supplemental brainstorming data from the team's collaborative "5 Why's" session to support the technical context of the Final Report, as visualized in the above image.

The analysis began at Step 1 with the core problem: it is challenging for youth facing housing insecurity to transition to independence, evidenced by youth lacking the means to live on their own, staying financially dependent, and facing a severe lack of immediate support. In Step 2, we identified a critical lack of systemic follow-through, where the financial support system fails to provide necessary mentorship, guidance, and lasting skills, leaving youth exposed to financial instability and a competitive job market. Step 3 maps a distinct lack of financial safety nets, noting that youth lack income for basic living expenses, lack emergency savings, and receive no formal training on asset management. Step 4 reveals that many youth lack budgeting and money-management skills; a knowledge gap worsened by systemic barriers like limited shelter capacities, resources that are hard to find, and programs that struggle to reach those who need them most. In Step 5, we traced this to program funding being short-term, unstable, and siloed; because initiatives operate in isolation without a long-term strategy, youth do not receive early, preventive financial literacy before entering independent living.

Ultimately, this sequential logic isolated the two main root causes highlighted at the bottom right of image: an educational gap where financial literacy resources are completely un-tailored to youth facing housing crises, and a structural gap where support services and information are deeply fragmented. We arrived at the ultimate conclusion that youth are not adequately prepared for independent living before they are forced to live independently.

Appendix B

Partner Feedback

- Housing instability vs housing insecurity
 - Community spaces
 - Diversion
 - Markers and indicators of issues
 - Something offered to parents as well
 - Pre employment support
- Partner engagement is necessary and none could result in failure of your project
- Funding?
- Consistency is key (mentors), people who will be permanent/highly committed to the program.
- How to package your solution as a product?
- Third spaces/community spaces; places that help in avoiding chronic homelessness.
- How to make sure the youth are incentivized to meet with their mentors in person? Especially after building an online relationship with their mentor(s)?
- Standardized mentor requirements from different sources (Government of Ontario, Government of Ottawa, etc.)
- Data Policy: what do you plan to do about data collection? Make that clear on the website
- The game is very detailed, how to keep the youths interested online?
- Be prepared with statistics about disenfranchised youth.

Appendix C

SDG Assessment



C5: Transition to Independence

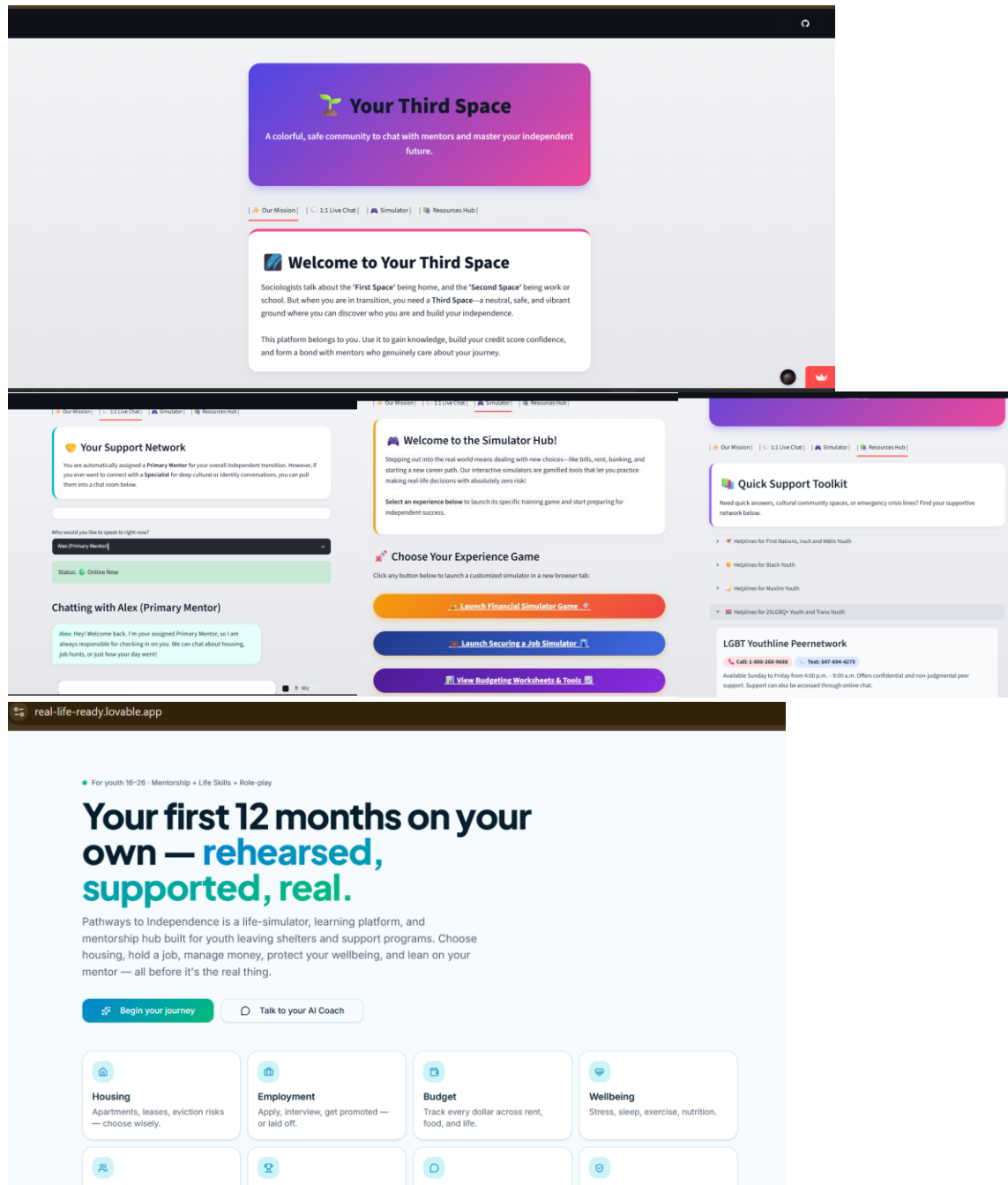


Figure 2: An image of the project’s initial SDG impact assessment

Appendix D

Website Screenshots

Images of the *Your Third Space* website and simulation game.



Appendix E

Supporting Materials

Images of a 3d Modelling of the in-person *Your Third Space* internet café.

